



Customer Reply Activity

Complete User and Administrator Guide

No eligible customer or supplier reply goes unnoticed.

This guide explains how to install, configure, use, maintain, and check the Customer Reply Activity module. It is written for business users, team managers, Odoo administrators, and implementation specialists. The language is practical, and every important setting is explained with examples.

DOCUMENT

User and Administrator Guide

MODULE

mail_customer_reply_activity

FORMAT

A4 documentation set

SUPPORT

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DOCUMENT MAP

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SECTION About This Guide

Customer and supplier replies normally arrive in the chatter of the related Odoo record. The conversation is stored, but a busy user can still miss the new message. Customer Reply Activity adds an action layer to the standard mail flow. An eligible external reply becomes an assigned activity with a deadline and a clear request to respond.

The module is not limited to CRM. An administrator creates one rule for each required model, such as Opportunity, Sales Order, Invoice, Purchase Order, Transfer, Project Task, or a custom business model. The rule tells Odoo where to find the responsible user and how the activity must behave.

Use this guide when you need to:

- understand what the module changes and what it keeps standard;
- prepare incoming and outgoing mail before configuration;
- create the first Customer Reply Activity rule;
- choose the correct model and responsible field;
- use the fallback responsible safely;
- control deadlines, merging, notifications, and sender exclusions;
- understand automatic-message filtering;
- manage activities during daily work;
- investigate a reply that did not create the expected activity;
- prepare a controlled rollout for several business teams.

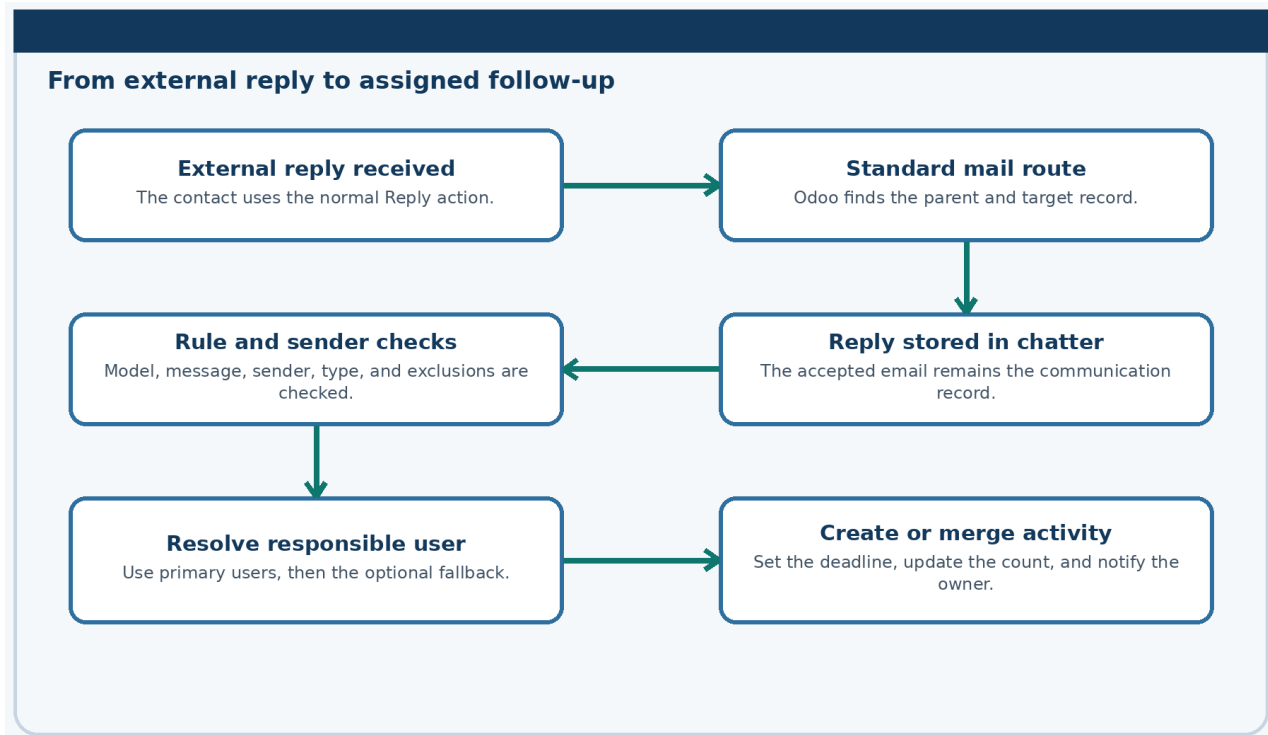
READING PATH New administrators should read Module Purpose, Before You Start, Quick Start, and Complete Rule Configuration first. Daily users can begin with Daily User Workflow. Experienced implementation specialists can use the field reference, decision rules, troubleshooting section, and companion technical guide as a reference.

SECTION Module Purpose

The main promise of the module is simple: an eligible customer or supplier reply should not depend on somebody noticing one more line in chatter.

When a reply is connected to an existing Odoo conversation, the normal mail engine first routes it to the correct business record. Customer Reply Activity then checks the active rule for that model. If the message and assignment are eligible, Odoo creates or updates an activity with the summary **Customer replied - response required**.

The original email remains in chatter. The activity does not replace the email and does not copy the full conversation into another system. It creates a visible responsibility on top of the accepted message.



Reply processing overview

The module helps solve five common problems:

- **Replies are easy to miss.** Chatter can contain notes, tracking values, internal comments, and email messages. An activity separates the required action from the conversation history.
- **Ownership is unclear.** The rule reads a user field directly from the record and assigns the follow-up to that user.
- **Records can be unassigned.** The optional fallback responsible provides a controlled second assignment level.
- **Several replies create noise.** Merge mode can keep one open activity while increasing the reply counter and sending a fresh reminder.
- **Mailboxes contain automated traffic.** Automatic-message checks and configurable sender exclusions reduce unwanted activities.

The module keeps standard Odoo behavior for mail routing, chatter, activities, user notification preferences, access rights on business records, and activity completion. It adds configuration and control at the point where an external reply has already been connected to a record.

SECTION Key Concepts

Understanding the terms below makes configuration much easier.

Term	Meaning in this module
Reply	An incoming email connected to an earlier Odoo message through normal reply headers and routed back to the same record.
Chatter	The message history on an Odoo record. The full accepted reply remains here.
Activity	A follow-up task assigned to an internal user. The module uses the summary Customer replied - response required.
Rule	A model-level configuration that defines assignment, activity type, deadline, merge policy, and filtering.
Model	The technical type of business record, for example an Opportunity, Sales Order, Purchase Order, or Project Task.

Term	Meaning in this module
Responsible Field	A field on the selected model that points to one or more Odoo users.
Fallback Responsible	An optional active internal user used only when the Responsible Field gives no eligible user.
Merge	Updating one matching open activity instead of creating a separate open activity for every reply.
External Sender	A sender who is not recognized as an internal Odoo user.
Automatic Message	A message identified by standard mail headers as an auto-reply, bulk message, mailing-list message, loop message, or delivery report.

An **eligible reply** must pass all main checks. It must be an external email, have a valid parent message, return to the same model and record, match an active rule, come from a valid non-excluded sender, pass the automatic-message policy, use a valid activity type, and resolve at least one eligible responsible user.

SECTION Before You Start

The module works after Odoo has received and routed an email. It cannot create an activity for a reply that never reaches the database. Confirm the mail foundation before creating rules.

Environment requirements

- The Odoo environment must allow installation of custom add-ons.
- The standard Mail application and its technical models must be available.
- The target business model must support both chatter and activities.
- An incoming mail route must receive replies and connect them to existing records.
- Users who will receive activities must be active internal users.
- An outgoing mail server is needed only when email delivery of activity notifications is required. The activity itself can still exist in Odoo without an outgoing email.

Mail readiness checklist

Before module testing, complete these checks in the same database:

1. Send an email from a real Odoo business record.
2. Reply from an external mailbox by using the normal **Reply** action.
3. Retrieve or process the incoming message through the configured mail route.
4. Confirm that the reply appears in the chatter of the original record.
5. Confirm that the sender address and subject are readable in the message.

If Step 4 fails, correct the standard incoming mail configuration first. Customer Reply Activity intentionally works after normal routing and does not replace it.

Access requirements

Rule management is restricted to system administrators. Daily users do not need access to the rule menu. They work with the assigned activity through the record, the activity menu, or their normal notification channel.

The module uses standard Odoo user types:

- **Internal user:** eligible for activity assignment when active.

- **Portal or public user:** not eligible for assignment.
- **Ordinary contact:** not eligible unless the contact is linked to an internal user account.
- **Inactive internal user:** not eligible as a responsible user, but the sender can still be recognized as internal when filtering employee replies.

START WITH ONE MODEL Configure and validate one high-value model before a wider rollout. An Opportunity or Sales Order is usually a clear first choice because ownership and external reply flows are easy to confirm. After the first rule works, repeat the same method for other models.

SECTION Installation and Initial Access

Installation procedure

1. Place the `mail_customer_reply_activity` directory in an Odoo add-ons path.
2. Restart the Odoo service so the add-on is visible to the registry.
3. Update the Apps list.
4. Find **Customer Reply Activity** and install it.
5. Open the configuration menu and create at least one active rule.

The module depends only on the standard `mail` add-on. Business applications such as CRM, Sales, Purchase, Inventory, Accounting, and Project are optional. Their models become available when the related applications are installed and when those models support chatter and activities.

Configuration menu locations

System administrators can open the rules from either path:

- **Settings > General Settings > Discuss > Customer Reply Activities**
- **Settings > Technical > Email > Customer Reply Activities**

The first path is convenient during normal administration. The Technical menu is useful when mail servers, email records, aliases, and activity configuration are being reviewed together.

Records installed by the module

Installation adds:

- the Customer Reply Activity Rule configuration model;
- list, form, and search views for rules;
- a Settings entry and a Technical Email menu entry;
- the generic **Customer Reply** activity type;
- customer-reply tracking fields on standard activities;
- access rights for system administrators;
- Russian interface translations for module labels and validation messages.

First access check

After installation, open **Customer Reply Activities**. The list should show columns for Model, Responsible Field, Fallback Responsible, Activity Type, Reaction Time, Reaction Unit, Merge Replies, and Automatic Message handling. If the menu is missing, confirm that the current user has system administration access and that the module installation completed.

SECTION Quick Start

This example creates a rule for Opportunities. The same method applies to other supported models.

Create the rule

1. Open **Settings > General Settings > Discuss**.
2. Click **Configure Customer Reply Activities**.
3. Click **New**.
4. Set **Model** to **Opportunity**.
5. Set **Responsible Field** to the field shown as **Salesperson** for the Opportunity model.
6. Select an active internal user in **Fallback Responsible**.
7. Keep **Activity Type** set to **Customer Reply**.
8. Set **Reaction Time** to 2 and **Reaction Unit** to **Days**.
9. Enable **Merge Replies**.
10. Enable **Ignore Automatic Messages**.
11. Keep the default sender exclusions and add any known company-specific automated senders.
12. Save the rule.

Validate the first real reply

1. Create a test Opportunity and assign a Salesperson.
2. Send an email from the Opportunity chatter to an external test mailbox.
3. Reply from the external mailbox without changing the conversation thread.
4. Process incoming mail.
5. Open the original Opportunity.
6. Confirm that the external reply is visible in chatter.
7. Confirm that one open Customer Reply activity exists.
8. Open the activity and check the assigned user, deadline, sender, subject, received time, and reply count.
9. Check the responsible user's activity view or notification channel.

Expected activity details:

- Activity type: **Customer Reply**
- Summary: **Customer replied - response required**
- Assigned to: the Opportunity Salesperson
- Deadline: the reply date plus two calendar days in the responsible user's timezone
- Note: sender, subject, received time, and **Replies in this activity: 1**

Validate the fallback

Remove the Salesperson from a separate test Opportunity and repeat the external reply flow. The new activity should be assigned to the configured Fallback Responsible. Restore ownership after the test if the record will remain in use.

Validate merge mode

Send a second external reply in the same conversation while the first activity is still open. The Opportunity should keep one open Customer Reply activity. Its reply count should become 2, and its note should show the latest reply details. The original deadline should remain unchanged.

SECTION Complete Rule Configuration

Every active rule defines one response policy for one model. Only one active rule can exist for the same model. An archived rule does not process new replies and allows another rule for that model to become active.

Field	Required	Purpose and correct use
Active	Yes	Controls whether the rule processes new replies. Archive a rule to pause it without deleting its configuration.
Model	Yes	Selects the business model whose routed replies can create activities. Only non-transient models with chatter and activities are available.
Responsible Field	Yes	Selects a Many2one or Many2many field on the model that points to Odoo users.
Fallback Responsible	No	Selects one active internal user used only when the responsible field gives no eligible user.
Activity Type	Yes	Selects the activity type used for new and merged customer-reply activities. It must be active and generic or linked to the selected model.
Reaction Time	Yes	Sets a non-negative calendar amount added to the reply date. Zero means the current date.
Reaction Unit	Yes	Defines whether Reaction Time is measured in days, weeks, or months.
Merge Replies	Yes	When enabled, later replies update one matching open activity. When disabled, each reply creates a separate activity.
Ignore Automatic Messages	Yes	When enabled, recognized automatic replies, bulk messages, mailing lists, delivery reports, and loops do not create activities.
Excluded Addresses	No	Defines exact senders, domains, or wildcard patterns that must never create a customer-reply activity.
Sequence	Advanced	Controls rule order in the list. It does not allow two active rules for the same model and does not change assignment priority.

Saving rules safely

Before saving, Odoo validates the relationship between the Model, Responsible Field, Activity Type, and Fallback Responsible. A validation message normally means that one selected value is not compatible with another. Correct the related field instead of trying to bypass the rule.

Changing the Model clears an incompatible Responsible Field. It can also clear an activity type that is restricted to a different model. Select the new model first, then reselect the assignment and activity fields.

SECTION Selecting the Model

The Model field controls the scope of the rule. It is not a filter for one team, stage, company, or record category. The rule applies to eligible replies on every record of that technical model.

The dropdown shows only models that:

- are not temporary wizard models;

- support chatter through the standard mail thread behavior;
- support scheduled activities;
- are available in the current Odoo registry.

Common model choices

Business process	Typical model choice	Typical responsible field label
Leads and opportunities	Opportunity or Lead	Salesperson
Quotations and confirmed orders	Sales Order	Salesperson
Customer invoices and related documents	Invoice or Journal Entry model	Salesperson or responsible user field available in the database
Requests for quotation and purchase orders	Purchase Order	Buyer
Delivery and receipt operations	Transfer	Responsible
Project work	Task	Assignees
Custom workflow	Custom model	A custom user field on that model

The exact labels depend on installed applications, custom fields, and interface language. The dropdown values in the rule form are authoritative.

Shared technical models

Some Odoo screens use the same technical model for several document types. For example, draft and confirmed Sales documents can share one model, and accounting documents can share another. A rule works at model level. If only a smaller record group must be included, additional customization is required.

One active rule per model

The module prevents two active rules from competing for the same model. To replace a rule:

1. Open the current rule.
2. Archive it.
3. Create or activate the replacement rule.
4. Run a reply test for the replacement.

Do not delete a rule only to pause processing. Archiving keeps the setup available for review and later reuse.

SECTION Responsible Users and Fallback Assignment

The Responsible Field defines primary ownership. It must belong to the selected model, use a Many2one or Many2many relation, and point to `res.users`.

Many2one assignment

A Many2one field contains one user. This is the normal choice for fields such as Salesperson, Buyer, or Responsible. If the user is active and internal, one activity is assigned to that user.

Many2many assignment

A Many2many field can contain several users, such as task assignees. The module creates or merges one activity for each eligible user. Duplicate user records are removed before scheduling.

Example: a Task has three assignees. Two are active internal users and one is a portal user. An eligible external reply creates an activity for each of the two internal users. The portal user does not receive an activity.

Eligibility rules

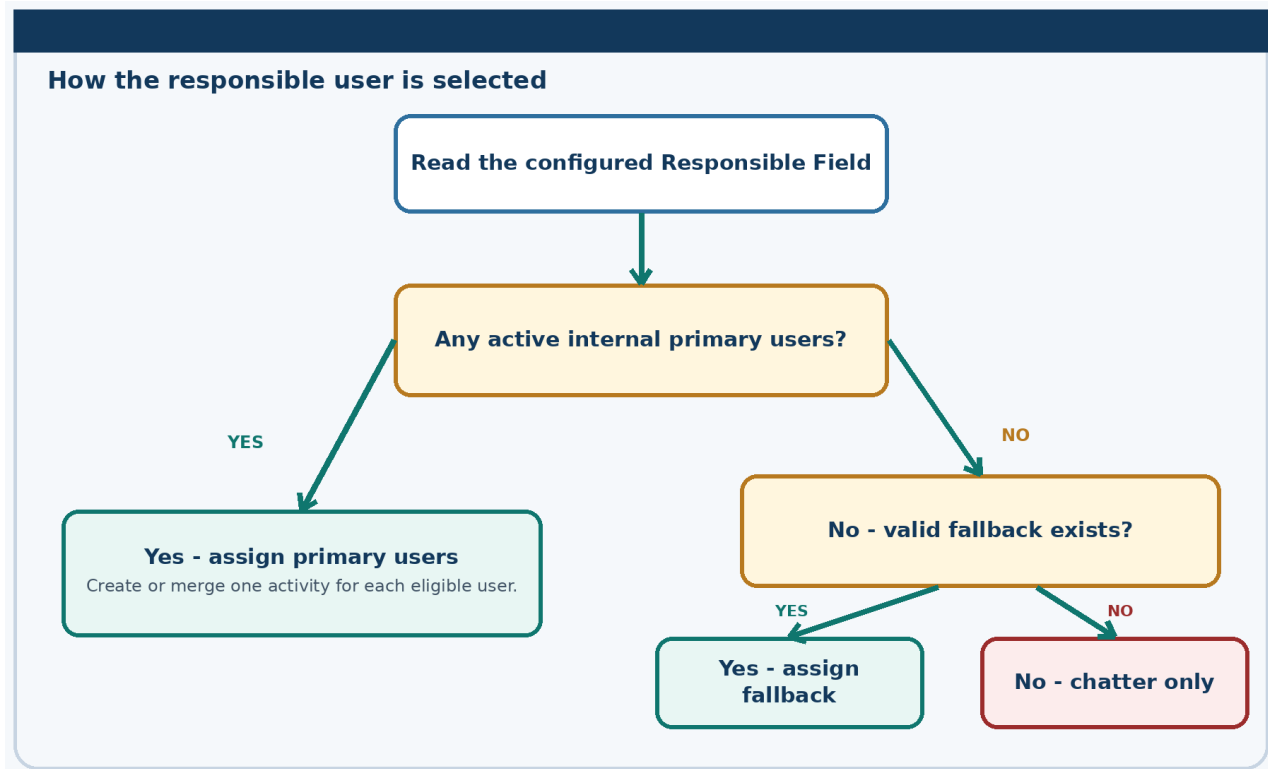
A primary or fallback user is eligible only when both conditions are true:

- the user account is active;
- the user is an internal Odoo user.

Portal users, public users, ordinary contacts, and inactive users are not assigned customer-reply activities.

Fallback decision

The fallback is used only when the Responsible Field is empty or contains no eligible users. It does not receive a second copy when a valid primary user exists.



Primary and fallback assignment decision

Assignment order:

1. Read all users from the configured Responsible Field.
2. Keep only active internal users.
3. If one or more users remain, assign an activity to each of them.
4. If no user remains, check the Fallback Responsible.
5. If the fallback is an active internal user, assign the activity to that user.
6. If no eligible user exists, leave the reply in chatter and create no activity.

The module never selects an unrelated administrator automatically. This makes missing ownership visible and predictable.

What happens when ownership changes

Merge matching includes the responsible user. If ownership changes after an activity was created, the old open activity is not moved automatically. A later reply is evaluated with the current record owner and can create a new activity for the new user. Managers should close or reassign the earlier activity according to the business handover process.

Recommended fallback choices

Choose a fallback who actively monitors the related process, for example:

- Sales Manager for Opportunities and Sales Orders;
- Purchase Manager for Purchase Orders;
- Accounting Manager for invoices;
- Warehouse Manager for Transfers;
- Project Manager for Tasks.

Avoid a general administrator who does not manage the business process. A fallback should be a real operational owner, not only a technical account.

SECTION Activity Types and Reaction Deadlines

Included activity type

The module installs a generic **Customer Reply** activity type. It has a reply icon, a danger decoration, and the default summary **Customer replied - response required**. Because it is generic, it can be used by rules for different models.

An administrator can select another existing activity type when it is:

- active; and
- generic, or specifically configured for the selected model.

The module protects active rules from an incompatible activity-type change. An activity type used by a rule cannot be deleted, and changes to its active state or model restriction are checked.

Reaction Time

Reaction Time is a non-negative whole number. Reaction Unit can be Days, Weeks, or Months. The calculation uses calendar dates, not business hours.

Configuration	Example result
0 Days	Activity is due on the current reply date.
1 Day	Reply on Monday gives a Tuesday deadline.
2 Weeks	Reply date plus fourteen calendar days.
1 Month	The same calendar day in the next month when available, following standard date rules.

The base date is evaluated in the responsible user's timezone. This matters when incoming mail is processed close to midnight and users work in different timezones.

Important deadline behavior in merge mode

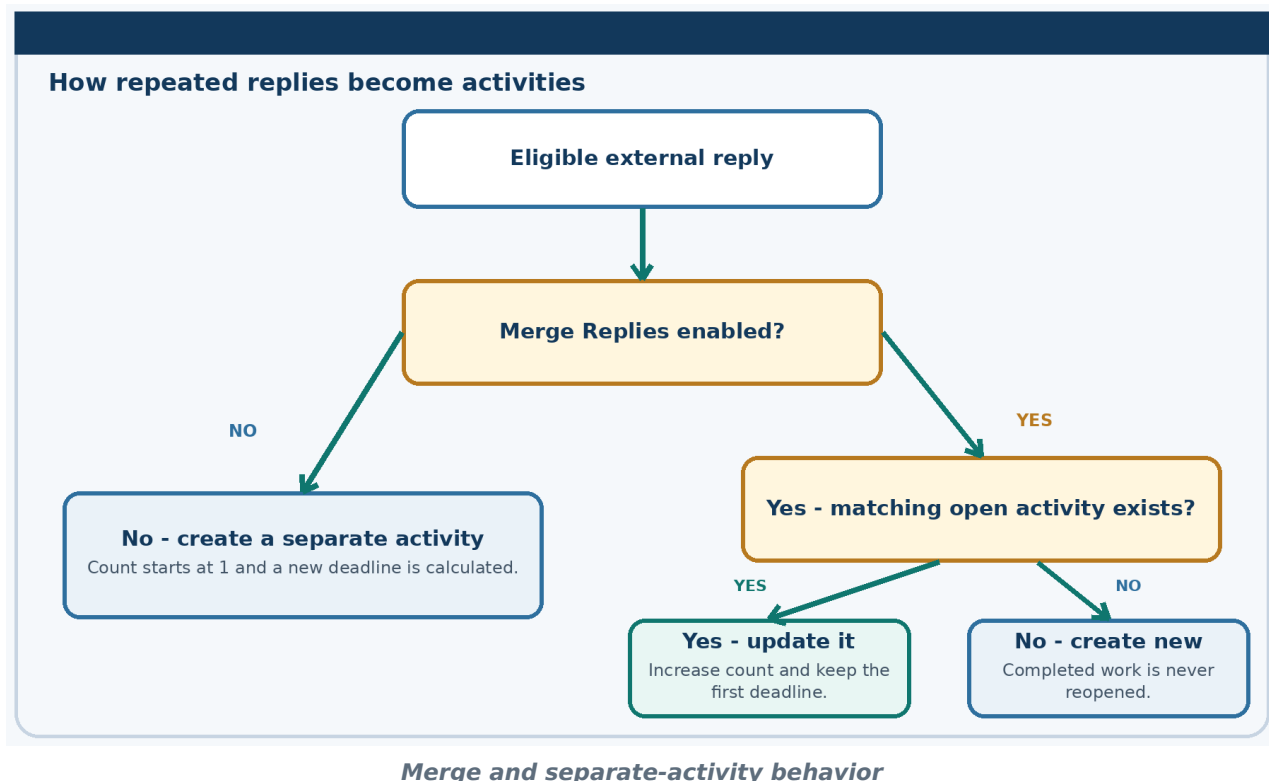
The first reply creates the deadline. Later merged replies do not move it. This prevents repeated messages from continuously postponing the original responsibility.

When the user completes the activity and another reply arrives, the module creates a new activity and calculates a new deadline from that later reply.

CALENDAR DEADLINE The standard activity deadline is a date. Hour-level response targets, working calendars, holidays, and escalation after a number of business hours are outside the base module.

SECTION Merge Replies in Detail

Merge Replies controls how repeated responses are represented in the activity list.



Merge Replies enabled

The module searches for one open activity with the same:

- rule;
- model;
- record;
- responsible user.

If a matching activity exists, the new reply updates it. The module:

- increases the reply count;
- stores the latest related chatter message;
- stores the latest received timestamp;
- rebuilds the note with the latest sender and subject;
- keeps the original deadline;
- sends one new reminder to the responsible user.

The user sees one open responsibility with the most recent context and a clear count of how many replies it represents.

Merge Replies disabled

Every eligible reply creates a separate activity with its own count of **1** and its own deadline. Use this mode when each email must be handled independently or when internal controls require one activity per message.

Completed activities

A completed activity is never reopened or reused. If a customer replies after completion, a new open activity is created. The earlier completed activity remains in the history.

Comparison

Situation	Merge enabled	Merge disabled
First eligible reply	Creates one activity with count 1.	Creates one activity with count 1.
Second reply while first activity is open	Updates the same activity and count becomes 2.	Creates a second activity.
Deadline after second reply	Original deadline remains.	Second activity receives its own deadline.
Notification after second reply	One reminder for the merged update.	Standard notification for the new activity.
Reply after activity completion	Creates a new activity with count 1.	Creates a new activity with count 1.

Choosing the correct mode

Enable merge when the business goal is **one open responsibility per conversation owner**. Disable merge when every incoming reply must remain a separate open work item.

For most sales and purchasing teams, merge mode gives a cleaner activity list while still notifying the owner about every reply.

SECTION Sender Exclusions

Sender exclusions prevent known addresses or domains from creating activities. They are useful for automated billing systems, marketplace notifications, monitoring tools, and other senders that are not real people asking for a response.

Patterns can be separated by new lines, spaces, commas, or semicolons. Matching is case-insensitive after the sender address is normalized.

Default exclusions

New rules include patterns for common automated mailboxes:

- no-reply@*
- noreply@*
- do-not-reply@*
- donotreply@*
- mailer-daemon@*
- postmaster@*

Keep these defaults unless the business intentionally expects real replies from one of these address formats.

Pattern reference

Pattern	What it matches	Example
<code>billing-bot@example.com</code>	One exact normalized sender address.	Matches only <code>billing-bot@example.com</code> .
<code>no-reply@*</code>	One local mailbox name at any domain.	Matches <code>no-reply@shop.example</code> and <code>no-reply@service.example</code> .
<code>*@example.com</code>	Any mailbox at one exact domain.	Matches <code>user@example.com</code> but not <code>user@sub.example.com</code> .
<code>@example.com</code>	Any mailbox at one exact domain.	Same domain-level result without writing a local part.
<code>example.com</code>	Any mailbox at one exact domain.	Useful when the whole domain must be excluded.
<code>*.example.com</code>	Any mailbox on a matching subdomain.	Matches <code>robot@alerts.example.com</code> ; add <code>example.com</code> separately for the base domain.
<code>robot@*.example.com</code>	One mailbox name across matching subdomains.	Matches <code>robot@eu.example.com</code> .

Safe configuration method

1. Start with the default patterns.
2. Review real unwanted senders in chatter.
3. Add the narrowest pattern that blocks the unwanted source.
4. Send a reply from an allowed address on the same domain.
5. Confirm that the allowed sender still creates an activity.

Avoid broad wildcards such as `*` or `*@*`. They can exclude every sender and defeat the purpose of the module.

Effect of an exclusion

An excluded reply still follows standard Odoo mail routing and remains in chatter. Only Customer Reply Activity processing is skipped.

SECTION Automatic and Internal Message Filtering

Ignore Automatic Messages

When this option is enabled, the module checks standard message headers that describe automatic or machine-created traffic. Recognized cases include:

- `Auto-Submitted` values that indicate an automated submission;
- `Precedence` values for auto-replies, bulk traffic, junk, or lists;
- common auto-reply and autoresponder headers;
- mail-loop and Exchange rule headers;
- `List-Id` and `List-Unsubscribe` mailing-list headers;
- an empty `Return-Path` used by many delivery reports;
- `multipart/report` delivery-status messages.

Auto-Submitted: no is treated as a normal message. A normal email without automatic indicators remains eligible.

The header X-Auto-Response-Suppress is not enough by itself to classify a message as automatic. It can be present on a genuine human email because it tells receiving systems which automatic responses to suppress. The module gives priority to preserving a real reply when this signal is ambiguous.

When to disable the option

Disable Ignore Automatic Messages only when the business wants every routed external reply to create an activity, including recognized automated messages. In most databases, keeping it enabled provides a cleaner and safer activity queue.

Automatic detection depends on headers supplied by the sender's mail system. No header-based filter can describe every provider. Add a sender exclusion when a known automated service does not identify itself through standard headers.

Internal sender detection

Employee replies should not create customer-response activities. The module checks both:

- the chatter message author and any internal user linked to that contact;
- the normalized sender email against active and inactive internal user accounts.

This second check covers cases where the incoming message is not linked to the expected author record but uses an employee email address.

Filtering order from a user's point of view

An incoming reply can remain in chatter without creating an activity when:

- no active rule exists for the routed model;
- it is an internal message;
- it is recognized as automatic and filtering is enabled;
- its sender matches an exclusion;
- the sender address is invalid;
- the configured activity type is no longer valid;
- no eligible primary or fallback responsible user exists.

This behavior is intentional. Chatter is the communication record; the activity is the actionable layer.

SECTION Daily User Workflow

Receiving the first activity

When the first eligible reply arrives, the responsible user receives one standard Odoo activity notification according to the user's notification preferences and mail configuration. The activity is also visible on the business record and in the standard activity views.

The activity note contains:

- **Customer reply received;**
- **From:** the latest sender text;
- **Subject:** the latest email subject;
- **Received:** the processing timestamp;

- **Replies in this activity:** the number of replies represented by this activity.

Recommended response process

1. Open the activity or the related business record.
2. Read the latest reply in chatter. Use the activity note to identify the sender and subject quickly.
3. Review earlier messages and the current business document.
4. Send the required response from the related record so the conversation remains connected.
5. Complete the activity only when no immediate response work remains.

Receiving a merged reply

If another reply arrives before completion and merge mode is enabled, the same activity is updated. The responsible user receives one new reminder. Reopen the record, read the latest chatter message, and respond. The reply counter helps show that the activity has new context.

Completing an activity

Completing the activity closes that responsibility. A future reply does not reopen it. Odoo creates a new activity with a new deadline. This keeps completed work historically correct while making the new request visible.

In-app and email notifications

The exact delivery channel follows standard Odoo settings. A user may see an in-app notification, an email, or both depending on configuration. If an email notification is not sent, the activity can still be created successfully and remain visible in Odoo.

Managers should monitor open and overdue activities through standard activity views. The module does not add a separate dashboard; it makes customer replies available inside the existing activity process.

SECTION Configuration Examples

The examples below use common labels. Select the actual model and user field shown in your database.

Opportunity follow-up

Goal: assign customer replies to the Salesperson and protect unassigned Opportunities.

- Model: Opportunity
- Responsible Field: Salesperson
- Fallback Responsible: Sales Manager
- Activity Type: Customer Reply
- Reaction Time: 1 Day
- Merge Replies: Enabled
- Ignore Automatic Messages: Enabled

Result: one open follow-up per Opportunity and responsible user. An unassigned Opportunity goes to the Sales Manager.

Quotation and Sales Order follow-up

Goal: use one policy for quotations and confirmed orders that share the Sales Order model.

- Model: Sales Order
- Responsible Field: Salesperson
- Fallback Responsible: Sales Operations Manager
- Reaction Time: 2 Days
- Merge Replies: Enabled

Result: an eligible reply to a quotation or order email becomes an activity for the current Salesperson.

Purchase Order supplier reply

Goal: make supplier responses visible to the Buyer.

- Model: Purchase Order
- Responsible Field: Buyer
- Fallback Responsible: Purchase Manager
- Reaction Time: 1 Day
- Merge Replies: Enabled
- Additional exclusion: known supplier portal notification domains, if required

Result: supplier replies create actionable follow-up for purchasing without treating employee responses as customer replies.

Project Task with several assignees

Goal: notify all active internal assignees.

- Model: Task
- Responsible Field: Assignees
- Fallback Responsible: Project Manager
- Reaction Time: 0 Days
- Merge Replies: Enabled

Result: each eligible assignee receives a separate activity. Later replies merge separately for each user.

Independent reply activities

Goal: preserve every message as a separate open responsibility.

- Model: the required business model
- Responsible Field: the operational owner
- Merge Replies: Disabled
- Reaction Time: the required calendar period

Result: two eligible replies create two activities, even when both belong to the same conversation.

Custom model

Before creating the rule, confirm that the custom model:

- supports chatter;
- supports activities;

- is not transient;
- has a Many2one or Many2many field linked to Odoo users;
- sends record-related email through standard Odoo mail functions;
- receives replies through normal message routing.

Then create the rule in the same way as for a standard model. No model-specific Python change is required for the basic workflow.

SECTION Managing Rules Over Time

Editing an active rule

Changes affect future reply processing. Existing open activities keep their stored rule link, owner, deadline, count, and latest message information until a later merged reply updates them or a user completes them.

Use this safe change process:

1. Record the current configuration.
2. Decide whether existing open activities must be completed or reassigned manually.
3. Change one group of settings at a time.
4. Save the rule.
5. Run a real external reply test.
6. Confirm chatter, assignment, deadline, merge result, and notification.

Archiving a rule

Archive a rule when the workflow must stop temporarily. New replies for that model do not create Customer Reply activities while no active rule exists. Existing activities remain available for completion.

Replacing a rule

Because only one active rule is allowed per model, archive the old rule before activating the replacement. Keep the old rule until the new policy has passed its acceptance test.

Changing the responsible field

A reply received after the change uses the new field. Existing open activities are not automatically reassigned. Review the handover with the affected team.

Changing merge mode

- Changing from enabled to disabled affects later replies only. The existing merged activity remains.
- Changing from disabled to enabled allows later replies to merge into a matching open activity created by the rule and assigned to the same user. If several matches exist from earlier separate mode, the oldest matching open activity is selected.

For a clean policy change, complete or review older open activities before switching modes.

Changing or deleting an activity type

An activity type used by a rule cannot be deleted. It must remain active and compatible with the selected model. Change the rule to another valid type before retiring the old type.

Multi-company databases

Rules do not have a company field. A rule applies to the selected model across the database. Responsibility still comes from each individual record, but separate reaction times or merge policies per company require an extension or a separate model design.

SECTION Troubleshooting

Start every investigation with two questions:

1. Did the incoming reply reach the correct record chatter?
2. Was an activity created or updated on that record?

This separates standard mail-routing issues from Customer Reply Activity configuration.

Symptom	Likely reason	What to check
Reply is missing from chatter.	Incoming mail or reply routing did not complete.	Incoming server, alias, catchall domain, message headers, mail logs, and the original outgoing message.
Reply is in chatter but no activity exists.	No active rule, filtered sender, invalid sender, automatic message, internal sender, invalid activity type, or no eligible user.	Rule status, selected model, exclusions, automatic-message option, sender identity, owner field, fallback, and server log.
Activity is assigned to the fallback.	Primary field is empty or contains no active internal user.	Open the record and inspect the configured Responsible Field.
No activity is assigned when fallback was expected.	Fallback is empty, inactive, or not an internal user.	Open the rule and reselect an active internal user.
Two activities exist for two replies.	Merge Replies is disabled, the first activity was completed, ownership changed, or the activities belong to different users.	Rule merge setting, activity status, responsible field history, and assigned users.
One activity remains but the count increased.	Merge Replies is working as designed.	Read the latest chatter message and activity note.
Deadline did not move after a second reply.	Merged replies preserve the first deadline.	Complete the old activity if the original responsibility is finished; a later reply will create a new deadline.
Activity exists but no email notification is visible.	User notification preference or outgoing mail configuration.	Activity assignment, user preferences, outgoing mail queue, and mail server.
An automated message created an activity.	Provider did not include a recognized header, or filtering is disabled.	Enable filtering and add a narrow sender exclusion for the source.
A real reply was excluded.	Sender pattern is too broad.	Replace broad domain or wildcard patterns with a narrower exact pattern and retest.
Model is not available in the rule.	The model does not support chatter and activities, is transient, or its application is not installed.	Model capabilities and installed applications.
Responsible field is not available.	The field does not point to Odoo users or belongs to another model.	Field type, relation, and selected model.
Activity type is not available.	It is inactive or restricted to another model.	Activity type active state and model restriction.

Symptom	Likely reason	What to check
A repeated copy of the same email did not create another activity.	The same Message-Id was already processed.	Confirm whether the mail server delivered a duplicate of the same message rather than a new reply.

Server log messages

Administrators may see warnings when a reply cannot become an activity because the sender address is invalid, the activity type is invalid, or no responsible user exists. These messages help explain the missing activity while the accepted email remains in chatter.

Processing failures are isolated with database savepoints. An activity-specific problem should not remove a reply that standard Odoo mail routing already accepted.

Notification investigation

When the activity exists but email delivery is unclear:

1. Confirm the activity is assigned to the expected user.
2. Confirm that the user is active and has a valid email.
3. Review the user's Odoo notification preference.
4. Check **Technical > Email > Emails** for the related outgoing record.
5. Review the outgoing mail server if the email is queued or failed.
6. Remember that the activity itself is the primary result; email is one possible delivery channel.

SECTION Scope and Limitations

The module has a focused purpose. Understanding the boundaries prevents incorrect expectations.

- Only replies connected to an existing Odoo message through standard reply headers are considered. A new email sent to an alias without a reply relationship is not a customer-reply activity.
- The routed reply must return to the same model and record as the parent message.
- The target model must support chatter and activities.
- An eligible responsible or fallback user is required for activity creation.
- Rules apply to a whole model. Record domains, teams, stages, VIP flags, and company-specific policies are not part of the base rule.
- Reaction deadlines use calendar dates. Business hours, holidays, and hour-based service targets are not included.
- The module does not provide escalation chains, manager reminders, response-time reports, or external chat-channel notifications.
- The module does not replace Helpdesk or provide a separate email client.
- Header-based automatic-message detection depends on information supplied by the sender's mail system.
- The module stores the latest reply reference and count on the activity; the full message history remains in chatter.

These limits keep the main promise clear and reliable: convert eligible external replies into owned follow-up work without replacing standard mail behavior.

SECTION Frequently Asked Questions

Does the module work only with Opportunities?

No. It works with any configured non-transient model that supports both chatter and activities and has a suitable user field.

Can one rule assign several users?

Yes. Select a Many2many field linked to Odoo users. Each active internal user in that field receives an activity.

Does the fallback also receive a copy when a primary user exists?

No. The fallback is a second assignment level, not an additional recipient.

What happens when no responsible user exists?

The reply remains in chatter, no activity is created, and the condition is recorded in the server log. The module does not select an arbitrary administrator.

Can several rules be active for the same model?

No. One active rule is allowed for each model. Archive the old rule before activating a replacement.

Does merge mode hide later replies?

No. The reply remains in chatter, the activity count increases, the note shows the latest reply, and the responsible user receives a fresh reminder.

Why does the original deadline remain after a merged reply?

The first reply created the responsibility. Keeping its deadline prevents later messages from delaying the required response.

What happens after the activity is completed?

A later eligible reply creates a new activity with count 1 and a new deadline.

Can the module create activities for a new email sent to an alias?

Not as a customer reply. The message must be connected to an earlier Odoo message and routed back to its record.

Are automatic messages deleted?

No. When standard routing accepts them, they remain in chatter. The filter only prevents creation of a Customer Reply activity.

Can the activity email be disabled while keeping the activity?

Notification delivery follows standard user preferences and mail configuration. The module always focuses on creating or updating the activity; the channel is controlled by Odoo.

Can each company use a different rule for the same model?

Not in the base module. The rule is database-wide for its model. Company-specific policies require an extension.

SECTION Administrator Checklists

First rule checklist

- Incoming reply reaches the correct chatter.
- Rule is active.
- Correct model is selected.
- Responsible Field points to internal users.
- Fallback Responsible is active and operationally appropriate.
- Activity Type is active and compatible.
- Reaction Time is non-negative and understood as calendar time.
- Merge policy matches the business process.
- Automatic-message filtering is enabled unless there is a clear reason to disable it.
- Sender exclusions are narrow and tested.
- One external reply creates the expected activity.
- One internal reply creates no customer activity.
- A second external reply follows the selected merge policy.
- A reply after completion creates a new activity.

Monthly administration checklist

- Review active rules and confirm each selected model is still used.
- Review fallback users for inactive or changed accounts.
- Check whether responsible fields still match team ownership.
- Review unwanted automated senders and add narrow exclusions.
- Review broad exclusions that may hide real contacts.
- Check overdue Customer Reply activities through standard activity views.
- Test one important inbound reply path after mail-server or domain changes.
- Confirm that activity notification delivery still matches user preferences.

Change checklist

- Record the old setting.
- Explain the policy change to affected users.
- Review existing open activities.
- Make one controlled change.
- Send a new external test reply.
- Verify chatter, owner, deadline, note, count, and notification.
- Keep evidence of the acceptance result.

SECTION Support Information

Technical name: `mail_customer_reply_activity`

License: LGPL-3

Support contact: full.stack.odoo@gmail.com

When requesting support, include the selected model, rule field values, record reference, expected responsible user, sender address, whether the reply appears in chatter, whether an activity exists, and any related server log message. Do not send mailbox passwords or private access credentials.